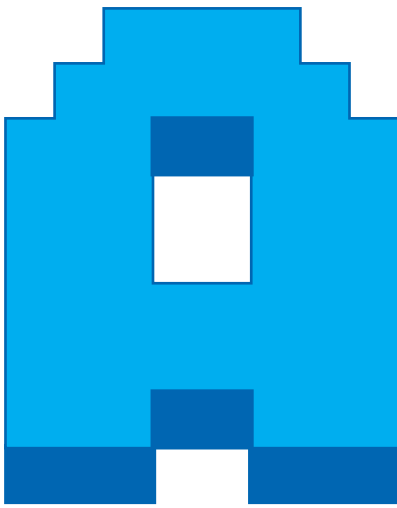


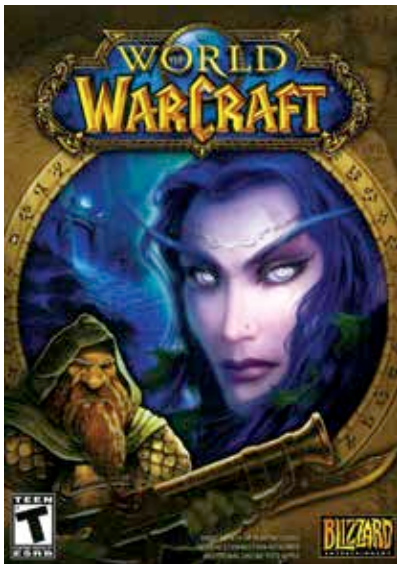


s the gaming industry heads

towards Games as a Service (GaaS), the issue of power creep tends to become more and more prominent. By GaaS, we mean games lasting a lot longer, with a constant inflow of new content and patches, online play becoming more prominent, and basically us as players spending a lot more time in persistent game worlds. Well, in this cover story we'll be discussing power creep; what exactly it is, why it happens, and also possible solutions for what can be done to possibly avoid power creep in games. Let's get started!

What exactly is power creep?

It's a fancy term to explain something quite simple really. Basically, power creep is what happens when newly-added content to a game – which can



WoW was the most played MMO for a long time before it was eventually dethroned

be played alongside the old-content mind you (this is important) – out-classes the old content. So much so, that there's no point or merit to continue using the old content since this new shinier content exists. With me so far? Let's use an example.

Take World of Warcraft, one of the most popular MMOs on the planet. Now, if you take a look at the level caps, the game first launched with a level cap of 60 (meaning this was the highest possible level your character could be). However, with each new expansion to the game, the level cap got pushed by 10 or so levels. At least, this was the case until the latest expansion, Shadowlands. Now, if you were around when the first few WoW expansions dropped, then you might have experienced this: You're level 60, you've got the best possible gear, then an expansion drops. The weakest uncommon rarity gear of the expansion is better than the gear you spent ages farming before the expansion dropped. Sure, you can get this new better gear easily but there's still the feeling that all that time you spent farming your BiS (best in slot) gear was pointless. Also, there's shiny new dungeons, which are faster, give more XP, and better loot. Meaning older dungeons are no longer getting any love from the devs and aren't played anymore because there's better dun-



Valheim is a great example of natural evolution or progression done well

geons to do. This is just one example of power creep.

Now I see you wondering, isn't that normal? Not quite. This is where natural evolution vs power creep comes in. Natural evolution in a video game is a good thing. Players who work on old existing content in order to unlock new content making the old content obsolete is completely fine. Here, we see that both the old and the new are getting equal amounts of attention from both the players and the devs. Old content isn't completely obsolete because you need it in order to access the new content.

Power creep is in many ways a developer cop-out. Let's provide the players with better loot and XP for doing a slightly better version of what they've already been doing. However, while this does provide immediate gratification to players, it has bad long term implications. For starters, it leads to rapid abandonment of old content, which spells bad news for games that want to last a long time. Then there's the negative experience that players face over time. If you're someone who quit playing a game or took a break for a while, only to return and find out that all the gear you worked so hard to acquire is now trash, well you're probably going to quit for good at that point. It only rewards players who consistently and actively play the game and want to keep throwing money at the developers.

Most games that run for long periods of time suffer from power creep. However, that doesn't mean that devs aren't actively making an effort to stop power creep. There are ways to prevent it, and many devs are actively taking steps to do so.